

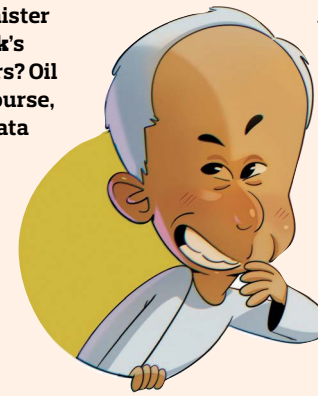
it's '*Badiya ronka layian Modi di scheme ne*' in Hamirpuri dialect, or the Bhojpuri hit '*Chal ri Kataniya*', there's a song to suit every political mood. Some are carefully-crafted ditties in praise of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's social sector schemes, the changes his government is bringing in people's lives, the glory he is bringing to the nation; others are a lyrical litany from the Opposition side, of how the country is getting centralised, how the poor still have no facilities while the rich are getting more. Whatever the tune, its end remains the same: get into people's heads so that the message—about the candidate, his party, its work—plays on an endless loop. ■



Meanwhile, what of the actress who played Seeta and Geeta in the 1972 film of the same name? Hema Malini will keep the BJP flag flying in Krishnabhoomi Mathura, from where she is contesting for a third time, oblivious to Sita aur Geeta's struggles in Jharkhand. ■

▶ ODISHA

THE LAST LAUGH



Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik's advice to BJP leaders? Oil your machine. Of course, the erudite Biju Janata Dal (BJD) veteran did not say so in so many words. But in a video circulated on his social media accounts on May 18, he hit out at his BJP counterparts who during their campaign promised to make Odisha the best state in India. Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma came in for a special mention, even as Naveen *babu* claimed that Assam's per capita deficit is double Odisha's and that BJP CMs have become a laughing stock among his people. A day earlier, he had dubbed *BJPwallahs* 'political tourists', sighted in Odisha only during elections. Well, at a time *Odia asmita* is a key plank and he the state chief minister for nearly a quarter of a century, the BJD supremo has the natural prerogative to stake a claim to be the leading champion of the Odia cause! ■

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

A NEUTRAL TURN



He was supposed to be a source of the BJP's strength in Uttar Pradesh. Instead, *bahubali* **Raja Bhaiya**'s change of heart is giving the saffron side some last-minute palpitations. Seven-time Kunda MLA Raghuraj Pratap Singh alias Raja Bhaiya has suddenly decided to go neutral, announcing that he will not support any political party or candidate this Lok Sabha election. Raja, a Thakur leader who had helped the BJP in the Rajya Sabha polls, wields influence in three Lok Sabha seats: Kaushambi, Pratapgarh and Prayagraj. Which is why his urging supporters to vote independently after meeting party leaders and workers at his residence in Pratapgarh has caught the BJP unawares even as the Samajwadi Party leaders interpret this as Raja Bhaiya giving them backdoor support. Raja Bhaiya also mentioned Rajput anger in UP in an interview, adding to the BJP unease in eastern UP. Kaushambi candidates of both parties approached the strongman seeking his support, but they do not seem to have moved him. Neutrality certainly means no support for the BJP, even if it is keeping SP hopes alive. ■

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